

To sell you on the idea, think of this: a visual representation of what's going on is very desirable. When you need to reschedule, all you do is type in a couple of quick words and drag a line here and there. Dependencies are programmed in, so you can test ideas one after the other and immediately visualise the what-if. When plans and resources change—as in when someone joins the team or the deadline is pulled back—you quickly know what you should be assigning to whom. You get the idea. And if you're still not sold, consider that you don't lose anything by giving it a trial run using your last project details—which you stored in your head.

Gaining From Gantt

Think project management and you should think Gantt charts. Put simply, these represent tasks against time, but they're powerful enough to have been used in the planning of such projects as dam and highway construction. If you know what they are, skip this; if you don't, we'll just quote a bit from ganttchart.com. A Gantt chart:

- ▣ allows you to assess how long a project should take.
- ▣ lays out the order in which tasks need to be carried out.
- ▣ helps manage dependencies between tasks.
- ▣ allows you to see immediately what should have been achieved at a point in time.
- ▣ allows you to see how remedial action may bring the project back on course.

GanttProject, the software at hand, is a small download from <http://ganttproject.biz>. It's for Linux, Mac, and Windows. To straightaway get up and running with it, all you need to be familiar with is the notions of tasks, assignments, and dependencies—which you probably are.

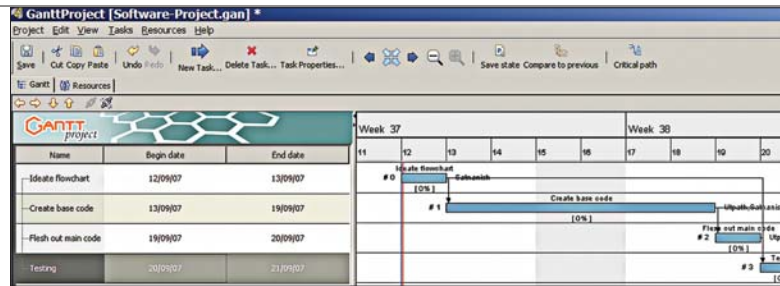
Now if you're thinking this is some old PIM-like productivity software, we can say from personal experience that all that's really there to project management is there in GanttProject. MS Project, incidentally, costs \$599 (Rs 24,250), and the feature set is pretty much the same—with two exceptions:

- you can't interact with a Microsoft Exchange Server, and you can't share the project over a network.

Getting Your Hands Not So Dirty

"Intuitive" best describes GanttProject as a piece of software. All you'll need ready before you start using it is:

- ▣ Who's working on the project
- ▣ Details such as when they're off work
- ▣ A breakdown of the project into tasks



Too complex a project wouldn't have been rendered well here, so here's just the basics—some people, some tasks, some dates. The left pane contains the details; the right pane displays the Gantt chart. Each task is in its own row, and arrows indicate dependencies. Dates are clearly marked, as are holidays (the grey vertical bar)

- ▣ An idea of how long each task should take to complete
- ▣ What task depends on which other(s)
- ▣ And so on. You'll realise more details as you get into the software.

Fire it up and you'll see that the act of adding people, adding tasks, and setting deadlines for them is as easy as can be. We first named the thing "Software-Project", and like any good piece of software would, it came up with categories of people to choose from—project head, coder, tester, and so on. Do the elementary stuff and you'll end up with something that looks as above.

Like any well-behaved Gantt chart, this one shows tasks against time—you can see the dates they're scheduled for, and at a glance, how long each task will take. Now, following the everything-at-a-glance philosophy, we chose to display the task name above the bar that represents the task, the progress of the task below the bar, and the person(s) involved to the right. In regards this last, note that you can assign dependencies. So if you say the coder is "dependant" upon the project head, then whenever you assign a new task to the coder, the project head's name will appear as if he were involved in the task, too. Dependencies between tasks are indicated by arrows. You can also create dependencies using the mouse: click on one task in the Gantt chart, [Ctrl] + Click on the other, and select "Link".

On the subject of dependencies, we should mention that they can be of four kinds: start to finish, finish to start, finish to finish, and start to start. "Finish to start" is the obvious one: the second starts when the first has finished. "Finish to finish" means they should end at the same time, and so on.

Now, we should warn you that the help file is skimpy. They aren't too articulate on the Web site, either—so you'll have to find some interesting stuff yourself: for example, the fact that you can change the public holiday schedule (from under the Resources menu).

Indenting and un-indenting tasks is easy, and what this does is this: if task B depends on task A, and you indent B making it a sub-task of A, the dates for task A will automatically change. This is natural, considering the definition of "sub-task."

Importantly, the chart will keep a proper track of progress only if you remember to feed in data on time. Someone completed something? Fill it in. Setback? Extend the task by dragging it using your mouse... And so on.